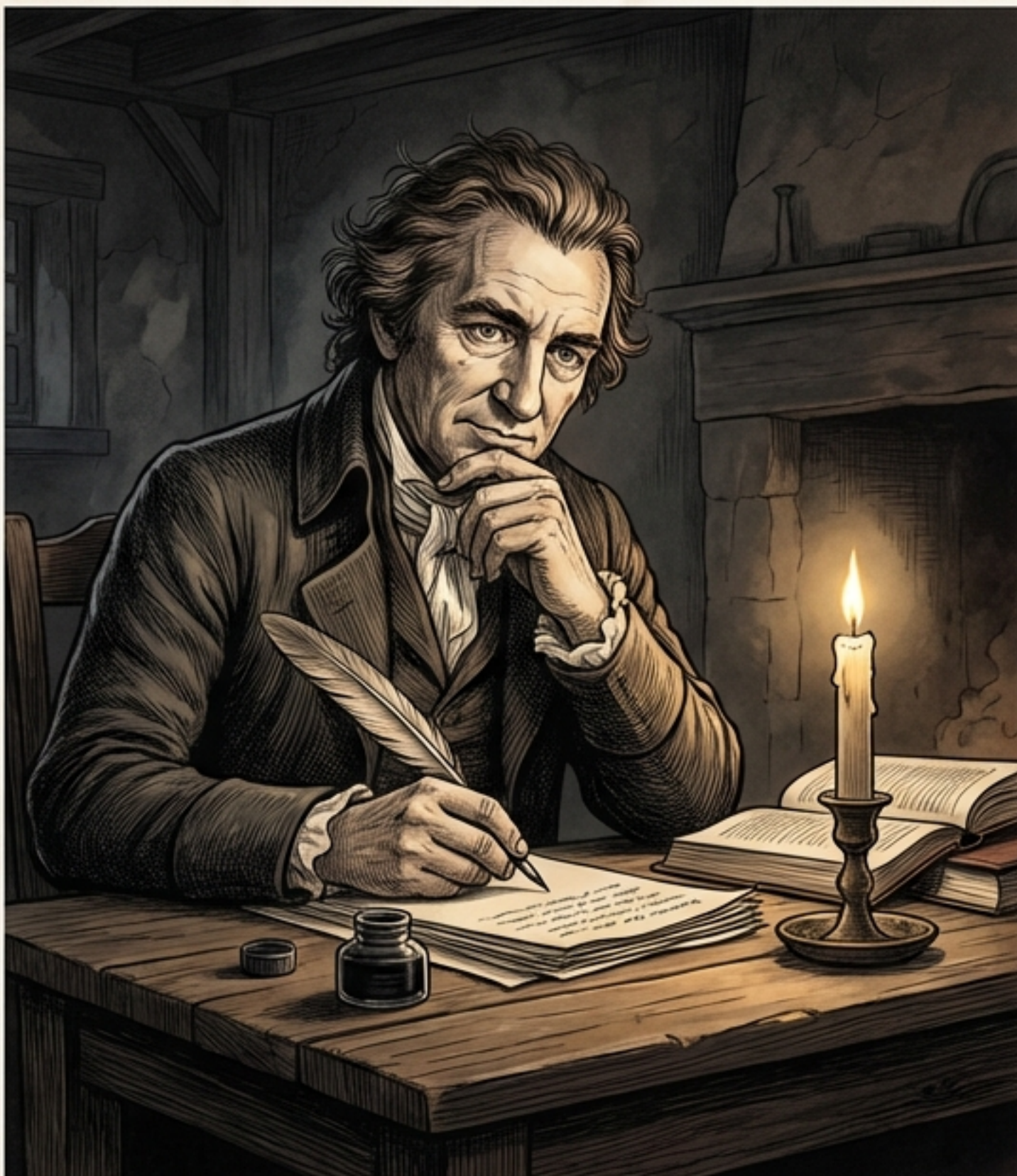


1776: A Colony's Crisis of Loyalty



By 1776, a deep conflict brewed in the American colonies. While many colonists believed Parliament had no right to legislate for them, most still felt a strong bond of allegiance to the British king. This was a people arguing with their government, not yet ready to abandon their king.



A Pamphlet Shatters the Silence

Thomas Paine, a British writer who had moved to Philadelphia, set out to change the colonists' entire mindset. In his pamphlet *Common Sense*, he argued it was time to challenge not just Parliament, but the very idea of a king.



The pamphlet was a sensation, selling over 500,000 copies in just six months and playing a pivotal role in moving the colonies toward revolution.

The Case Against the Crown

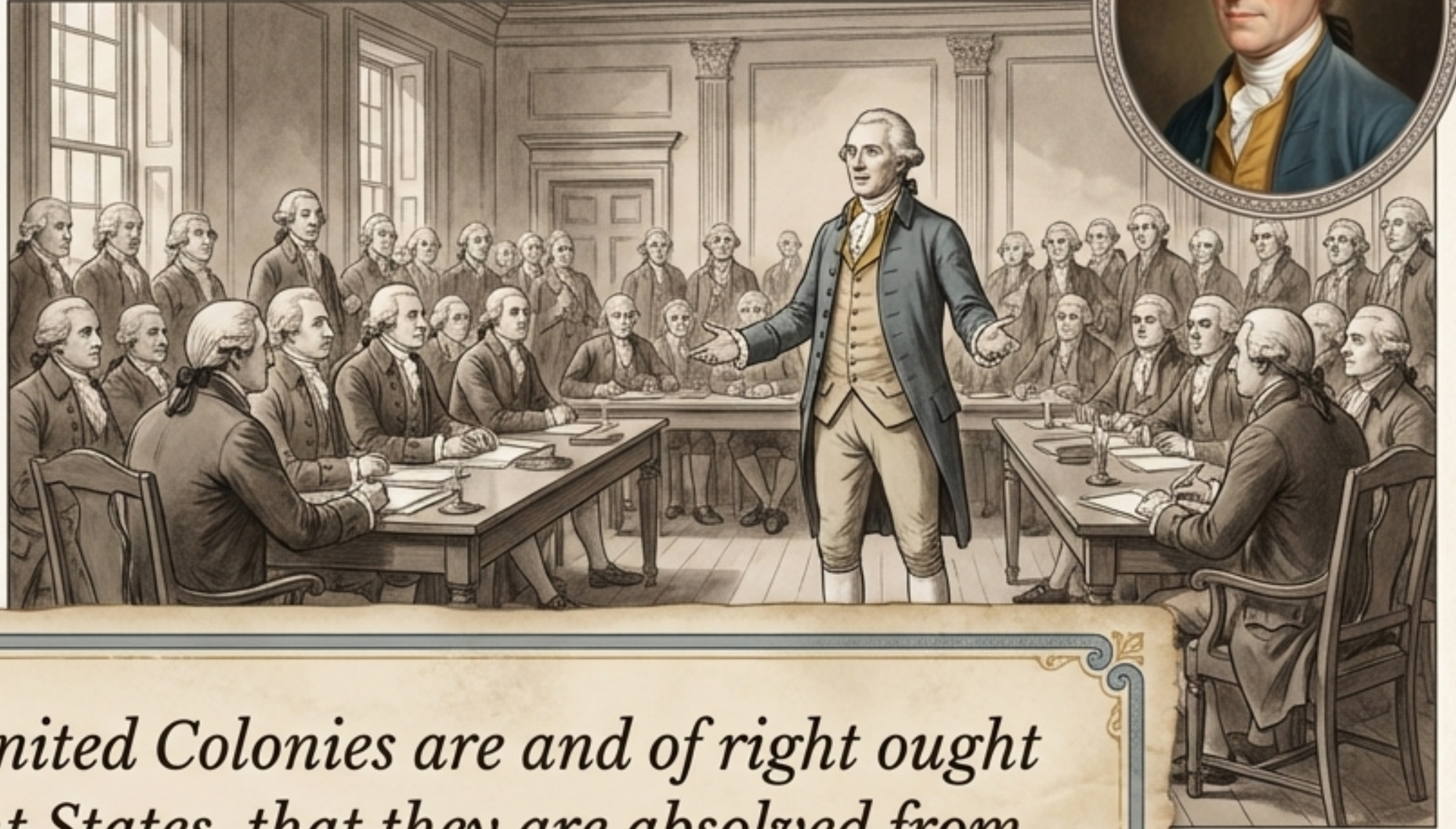
Of more worth is one honest man to society and in the sight of God, than all the crowned ruffians that ever lived.

Paine argued that Britain had not helped the colonies out of kindness, but for its 'own profit.'

Everything that is right or reasonable pleads for separation. 'Tis time to part.

The Idea Becomes a Resolution

Paine's arguments deeply impressed members of the Continental Congress. In June 1776, Virginia's **Richard Henry Lee** stood before the Congress and introduced a formal resolution for independence.



Resolved, That these United Colonies are and of right ought to be, free and independent States, that they are absolved from all allegiance to the British Crown...

The Price of Failure: A Traitor's Death

The delegates faced a terrifying decision. Once independence was declared, there could be no turning back. If they were captured by the British, they would be hanged as traitors.

Traitor: A person who betrays his or her country.

A Committee to Tell the World Why

After long debate, Congress appointed a committee to draft a formal declaration of independence. Their job was to explain the reasons for the colonies breaking away from Britain.



John Adams



Benjamin Franklin



Thomas Jefferson



Robert Livingston



Roger Sherman



John Adams

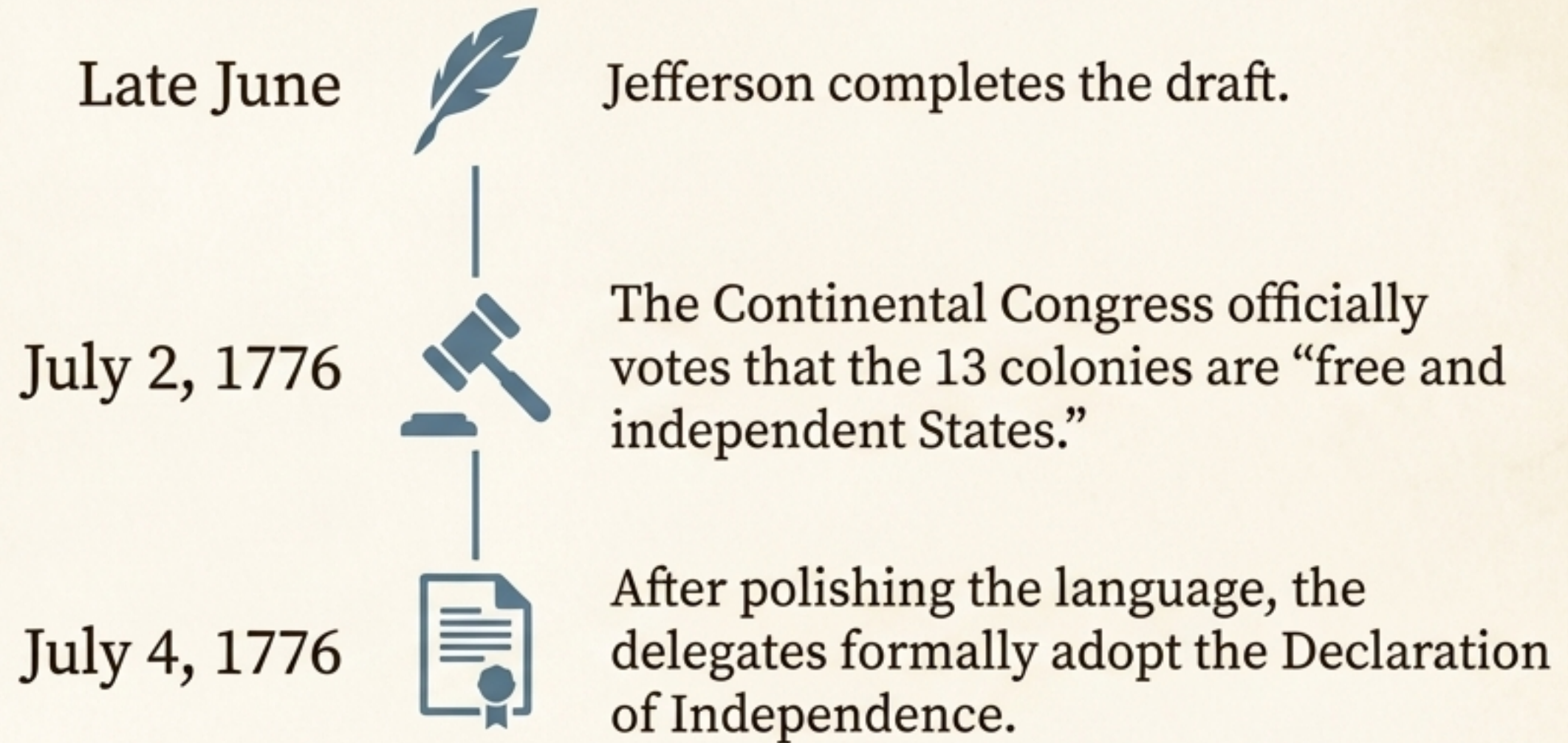


Roger Sherman

Spotlight on Jefferson

The committee chose Thomas Jefferson, a quiet Virginian known for his clear and graceful writing, to be the primary author.

From Draft to Declaration: The Fateful Days of July



The Signature



John Hancock, president of the Congress, signed first. He penned his signature in large, clear letters, remarking, “*There, I guess King George will be able to read that.*”

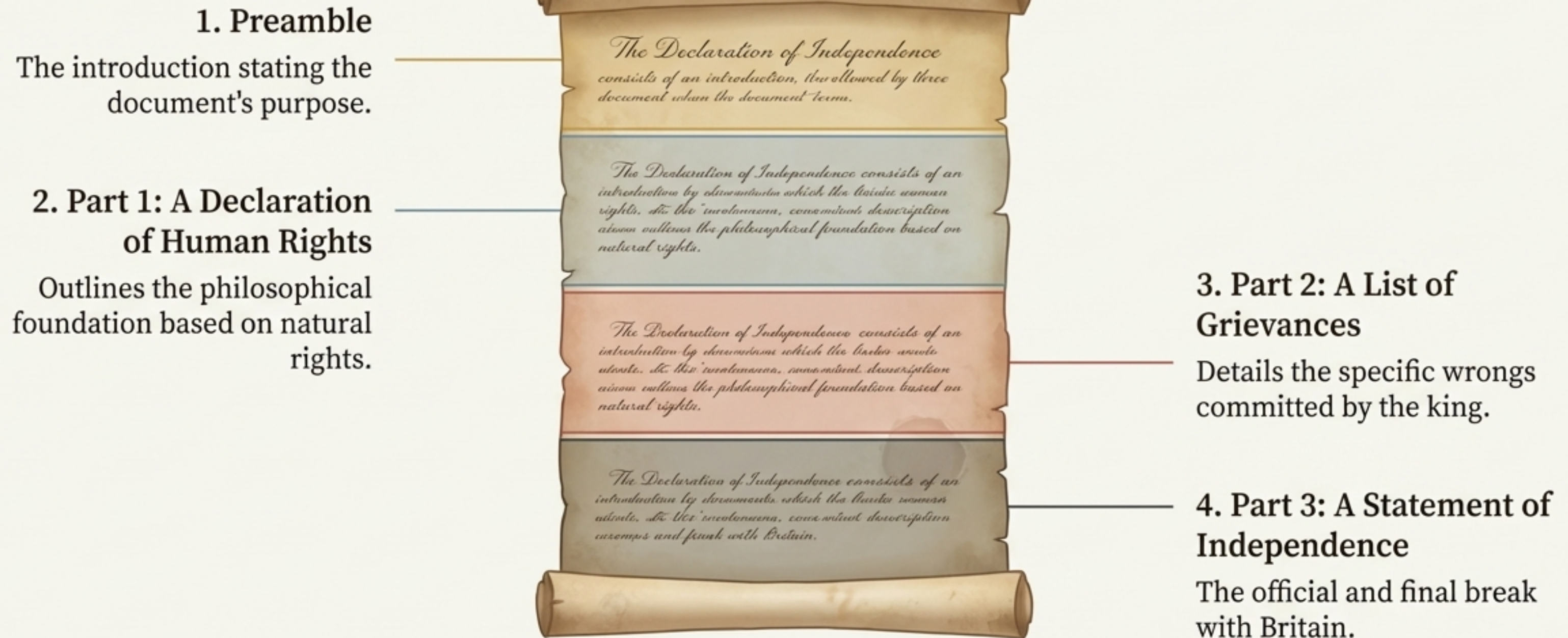
A New Nation Celebrates with Fire and Fury



Copies of the Declaration were printed and distributed throughout the colonies. Patriots greeted the news with joyous and sometimes rowdy celebrations, confirming that this was a declaration by and for the people.

The Anatomy of a Declaration

The Declaration of Independence consists of an introduction followed by three main parts:



All Men Are Created Equal

We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal; that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable rights; that among these are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.

Core Philosophy: Natural Rights

The first section stresses the idea of natural rights—rights that belong to all people from birth and cannot be taken away by governments.

The Purpose of Government

The text explains that people form governments to protect these rights, and that governments can only exist with the “consent of the governed.”

The Case Against King George III

The second part of the Declaration lists the grievances that led the colonists to rebel. Jefferson argued that the colonists had repeatedly petitioned the king to correct these injustices, only to be met with “repeated injury.”

The Verdict:

“A prince whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a tyrant is unfit to be the ruler of a free people.”

Key Grievances Listed



Disbanding colonial legislatures



Sending troops to the colonies in peacetime



Imposing limits on trade



Levying taxes without the consent of the people

The United States of America is Born



The Final Act The last part of the Declaration formally announces that the colonies are now the “United States of America.” All political ties with Britain are cut.

The Powers of a New Nation: As a free and independent country, the United States now has the full power to:

- ★ Levy War
- ★ Conclude Peace
- ★ Contract Alliances
- ★ Establish Commerce

A Pledge of Lives, Fortunes, and Sacred Honor

The signers closed the Declaration with a solemn vow, demonstrating their complete commitment to the cause and to one another.

And, for the support of this declaration, with a firm reliance on the protection of Divine Providence, we mutually pledge to each other our lives, our fortunes, and our sacred honor.

John Hancock

W. B. Perry
Presbington
M. Poi

John W. C. R.
John H. Brown
Back of Iron Noyreth

John Francis
Mogard Broth
John Handley

John H. Henson

A. West
H. Honan
Groctation
Hart Shere

John Hancock

J. D. W. Mitch

Alonzo Felt

Willes Wells

W. C. Jones

W. C. Jones

W. H. Henson

Willes Bernard

John E. Grand

W. C. Jones

John Writter

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